

Mio, the “America Village” (emigration to Canada)

Then-and-now aerial photographs, how the ground was made, and the disasters people chose to remember — compiled automatically from public Japanese government data.



三尾・アメリカ村（和歌山県美浜町）

Study area	2.4 km × 1.5 km around 33.8914° N, 135.0894° E
Oldest aerial photograph	1961–1969
Aerial series in this brief	1961–1969, 1974–1978, 2019
Main natural landform	Mountains (58%)
Former river channels	none mapped
Filled, reclaimed or drained land	none mapped
Former sea, river or pond	none mapped
Meiji-era paddies, marsh and flats	none mapped
Disaster memorials within 3 km	0

What this brief is. A reading aid for comparing the same ground across decades. It shows what the photographs and GSI's land surveys record; it does not describe current conditions, access or opening hours.

What it is not. Not a hazard assessment or a property survey. Landform classes describe typical tendencies of the ground; for present-day risk, read the official hazard map of the municipality.

Edition 2026-09-27. Aerial photographs, landform and Meiji-era lowland data: Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), processed by Japan Time Atlas. Memorial data: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials, summarised and translated by Japan Time Atlas.

The same ground, 1961–1969 and 2019



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2019 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2019*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

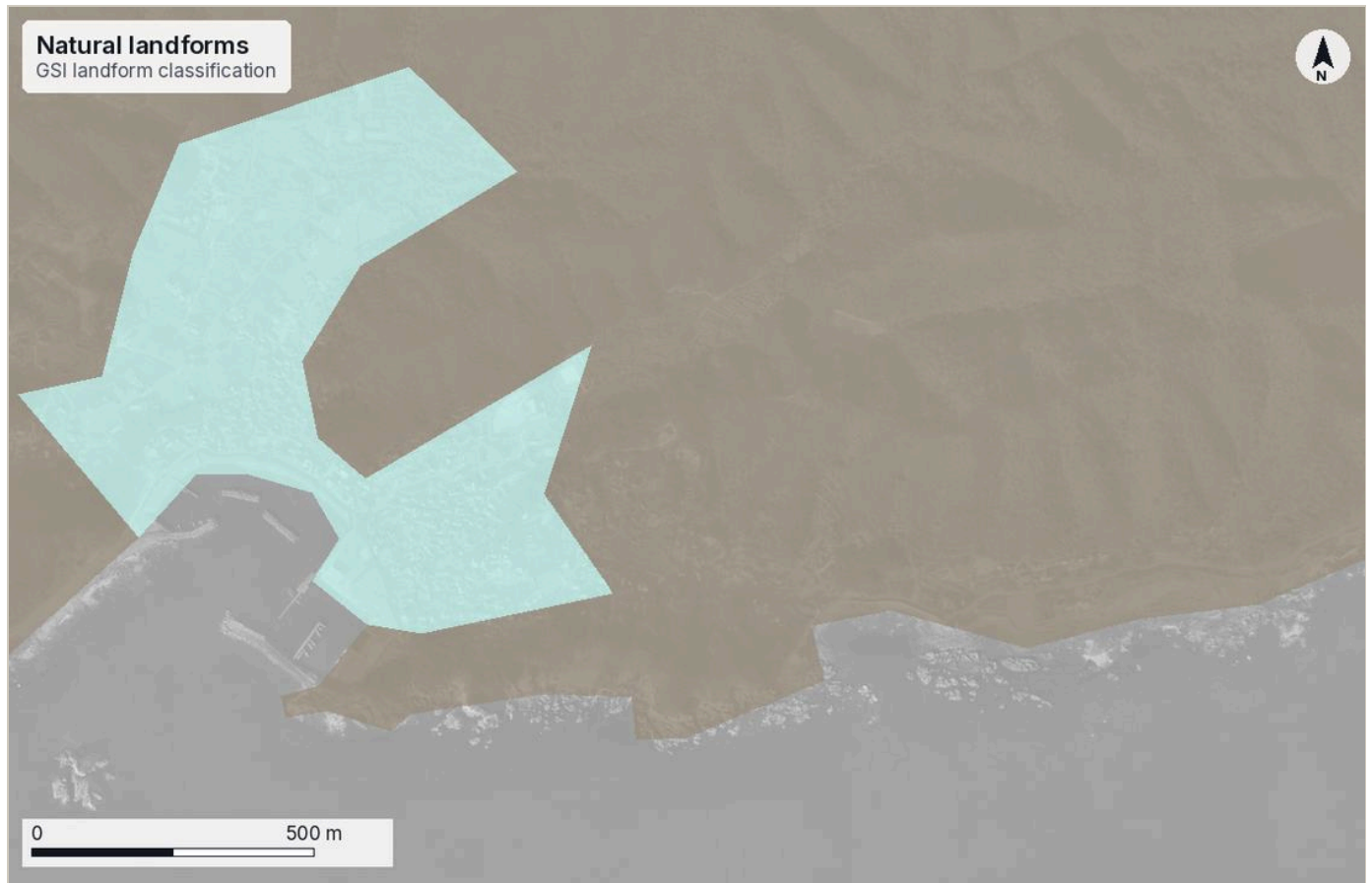
The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1974-1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

 Mountains 58%

 Lowland 13%

GSI has no detailed landform survey for this frame, so the map uses GSI's regional classification (compiled for zoom levels 9–13). It shows the broad landform only; former river channels and man-made ground are not mapped at that scale.

What the main landforms mean

Mountains (58%). Terrain of high ridges and valleys. Watch for slope disasters.

Lowland (13%). Flat land built from sand, gravel and mud laid down by rivers or the sea. River flooding, storm surge and liquefaction; shakes easily in earthquakes.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.

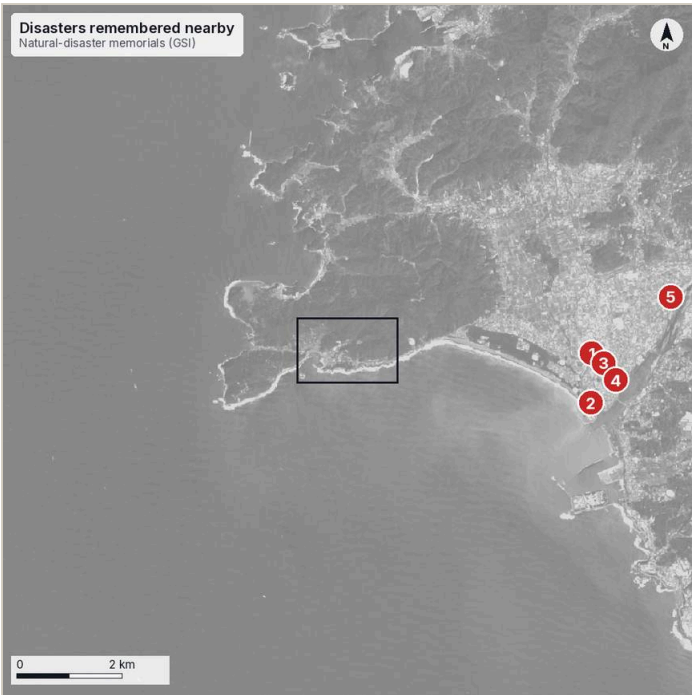
Man-made ground

No man-made ground mapped in this frame.

Meiji-era lowland

GSI has not traced Meiji-era lowland for this frame.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1 Flood-level marker for the 1953 Kishu flood 水位標	Great Kishu flood (18 Jul 1953) · flood	1958	5.8 km
2 Stone record of the 1854 Ansei Nankai tsunami 津浪之紀事	Ansei Nankai earthquake (24 Dec 1854) · earthquake / tsunami	1862	5.9 km
3 Monument of Murata Yoshinari, recalling the 1889 Hidaka River flood 村田美成の碑	Great Kii Peninsula flood (19–20 Aug 1889) · flood	1894	6.1 km
4 Monument to the 1953 Kishu flood in Gobo 水害之碑	Great Kishu flood (18 Jul 1953) · flood	1954	6.4 km
5 Monument to the restoration of Fujii's farmland after the 1953 Kishu flood 藤井の耕地復旧記念碑	Great Kishu flood (18 Jul 1953) · flood	1962	7.7 km

What the memorials record

1. **Flood-level marker for the 1953 Kishu flood.** The heavy rain of 18 July 1953 broke the embankments; the torrent destroyed hundreds of houses in an instant and laid waste more than 600 hectares of farmland. The marker records the flood level so that the disaster is not forgotten, though it has been moved since it was set up and may no longer show the true level.
2. **Stone record of the 1854 Ansei Nankai tsunami.** The Ansei Nankai earthquake of 24 December 1854 brought a tsunami to Mihama, and people who fled onto the river in boats were sunk by it. The inscription teaches that great earthquakes bring tsunamis and that people should take refuge on the higher ground of the great pine grove.
3. **Monument of Murata Yoshinari, recalling the 1889 Hidaka River flood.** Heavy rain on 19–20 August 1889 broke the embankments of the Hidaka River, and the torrent swept away many houses, people and livestock. The flood is said to have killed 219 people.
4. **Monument to the 1953 Kishu flood in Gobo.** Heavy rain of up to 600 mm on 18 July 1953 made the Hidaka River overflow. Across Gobo City 26 people died, 100 went missing and about 3,000 were injured; an estimated 4,000 houses were flooded above floor level, 365 of them swept away, and recovery took several years. The monument urges future generations never to lose their wariness of nature.
5. **Monument to the restoration of Fujii's farmland after the 1953 Kishu flood.** Heavy rain that had fallen since the night before struck all of Kishu on 18 July 1953, hitting the Arida and Hidaka river basins hardest. Landslides filled valleys, embankments broke, torrents swept away people and houses, and farmland was badly devastated. The monument first stood by the prefectural road at Fujii and now stands on the Gobo–Miyama road at Yoshida.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Where every element comes from

- **Aerial photographs** (pp. 2–3) — Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), GSI Tiles: series *ort_old10* (1961–1969), *gazo1* (1974–1978) and *nendophoto2019*. Cropped, resized and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. List of GSI Tiles: <https://maps.gsi.go.jp/development/ichiran.html>
- **Landform classification** (pp. 4–5) — GSI landform-classification vector tiles (natural and artificial landforms), compiled by GSI from its Land Condition Maps, Flood Control Terrain Classification Maps and vulnerable-landform surveys. Rendered, measured and translated into English by Japan Time Atlas. https://github.com/gsi-cyberjapan/experimental_landformclassification
- **Meiji-era lowland** (p. 5) — GSI “明治期の低湿地” tiles and legend (https://maps.gsi.go.jp/legend/lw_legend.pdf), measured and translated by Japan Time Atlas.
- **Natural disaster memorials** (p. 6) — GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑), registered by municipalities, <https://www.gsi.go.jp/bousaichiri/denshouhi.html>; processed by Japan Time Atlas (selection by distance, English translation and summary). Memorial photographs are not reproduced.
- GSI content is used under the GSI Content Terms of Use, which follow the Public Data License v1.0 (PDL1.0, compatible with CC BY 4.0). Data retrieved 2026-09-27.
- **Outline of Japan** — Data of Japan / JapanPrefGeoJson (public domain), simplified.

Method

The study area is a fixed rectangle of 2.4 × 1.5 km. Every GSI photo series that covers at least 85% of it is included; the newest annual orthophoto covering at least 90% of it is used as “now”, with any gap filled from GSI's latest seamless mosaic. Landform shares are areas of the rectangle measured on GSI's polygons at zoom level 14, each class merged before measuring. Meiji-era shares count map pixels by legend color. Memorials are selected by straight-line distance from the center of the study area.

Limits

Historical series are mosaics of photographs taken on different dates; GSI publishes the flight date of each photograph. Landform data record conditions at the time of survey. Nothing in this brief shows present-day access, safety or opening hours.

Area Dossier. The same district with a 4–8 page English history, written from Japanese library sources and cited page by page.

Deep Research. A single hamlet or address, researched in libraries and archives.

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